for a month at Khreu. This was also agreed to. But this was not the end. It was clear to me that my performance hereafter would have to justify the strong stand that I had taken or I ought to be prepared to face the guillotine! Like the CO who was sacked, for me also the writing was on the wall: 'perform or perish'.

As a result of this bungled operation, my brigade and I had gone down below the zero line in operational performance. I had barely done one month in command. However, we took up the challenge, and our results in the months to follow spoke for our actions. In the next one-and-a-half years, the same battalion, the 2/11 Gorkha Rifles (GR) led by Colonel N.K. Pradhan, became one of the most decorated units in the entire corps. The battalion received the 'Unit Citation' from the army chief in recognition of its performance during 1991–92. The other units did equally well and contributed handsomely to make our brigade's achievements the envy of the rest of the command.

Intelligence was received by the Corps HQ that terrorists were planning to unfurl the flag of independent Kashmir on 26 January 1991 at Pahalgam, which had been declared as 'liberated territory'. Moreover, the situation in Anantnag had deteriorated so much that the deputy commissioner and the superintendant of police were functioning from their residences south of the Jhelum river – it had become unsafe for them to operate from their offices in the town. My brigade was ordered to move to Anantnag forthwith. I deployed one battalion, the 12 Rajputana Rifles, in Pahalgam and Aish Muqam areas and the other two, 17 J&K Rifles and 2/11 GR, in Anantnag. I was given one more battalion, the 1/11 GR, and we cordoned off the entire town of Anantnag, which had a population of over 50,000 people, and other important areas. Entry and exit was controlled by establishment of checkpoints on all roads leading to the town. Something like this had never been attempted before. This step took the terrorists by surprise and they were definitely caught on the wrong foot. Nothing untoward happened on Republic Day and even thereafter. The situation became almost normal.

As part of the plan to sanitize Anantnag and its environs, we launched Operation 'Just Resolve' on 14 March 1991. The town had